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GREEK TRAGEDY

EURIPIDES

Rhesus

Playwright	Euripides
Translated by	Gilbert Murray
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after this page, because their terms travel with the text.
Transmitted among Euripides' plays but probably written by someone else in the fourth century. Read it as evidence of how the repertoire was assembled, and as a war play built entirely out of darkness and eavesdropping.

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*** START OF THE PROJECT GUTENBERG EBOOK THE RHESUS OF EURIPIDES ***

RHESUS

CHARACTERS OF THE PLAY

HECTOR, _Prince of Ilion and General of the Trojan Armies_.
AENEAS, _a Trojan Prince_.
DOLON, _a Trojan_.
PARIS, _also called_ ALEXANDER, _brother of Hector_.
RHESUS, _King of Thrace, son of the River Str[^y]mon and the Muse of the Mountains_.
A THRACIAN, _the King's charioteer_.
ODYSSEUS, _a Greek chieftain, famous for craft and daring_.
DIOMEDES, _a Greek chieftain, famous for valour_.
A SHEPHERD.

The Goddess ATHENA.
The MUSE OF THE MOUNTAINS.

CHORUS _of Trojan Guards with their_ LEADER.
Some THRACIANS _with their_ CAPTAIN, _Attendants, &c._

The date and authorship of the play are unknown; it probably belongs to the Fifth Century B.C., and is attributed to Euripides.

RHESUS

_It is a cloudy but moonlight night on the plain before Troy. [vv. 1-10]
The Trojans and their allies have won a decisive victory and
are camping on the open field close to the Greek outposts.
The scene is in front of a rude tent or hut that has been set
up for_ HECTOR, _the Trojan leader. A watch-fire burns low in
front. Far off at the back can be seen rows of watch-fires in
the Greek camp. The road to Troy is in front to the left; the
road to Mount Ida leads far away to the right._

_All is silence; then a noise outside. Enter tumultuously a band
of Trojan Pickets._

VARIOUS VOICES.

(_The dash -- in these passages indicates a new speaker._)

On to the Prince's quarters!--Ho!
Who is awake? What man-at-arms,
Or squire or groom?--Let Hector know
New rumour of alarms
From sentinels who stand at mark
The four long watches of the dark,
While others sleep.--Uplift thine head,
O Hector! On thine elbow rise,
Unhood the eagle of thine eyes,
Up from thy leaf-strewn bed!--

Lord Hector!

HECTOR (_coming out from the tent_). [vv. 11-28]

Who goes there? Who cries?
A friend? The watchword! . . . By what right
Do men come prowling in the night
Across my quarters? Come! Speak out.

LEADER.

A picket, Lord.

HECTOR.

In such a rout?

LEADER.

Be not afraid, Lord.

HECTOR.

I am not.
Is there an ambush? No? Then what,
In God's name, brings you from your post
With no clear tale to speak,
To spread this turmoil through a host
That lies in harness--do ye all
Know nothing?--out against the wall
And gateways of the Greek?

CHORUS (_various voices confusedly_). [_Strophe._

To arms! To arms, Lord Hector!--Send
First where the allied armies lie,
Bid them draw sword and make an end
Of sleep.--Let someone fly
And get the horses' armour on!--
Who goes with me to Panthooes' son?--
Who's for Sarpedon and the Lycians?--None [vv. 29-54]
Hath seen the priest go by?--
Ho, Captain of the Runners, ho!--
Ho, Trojans of the horned bow!
String, string! For need is nigh.

HECTOR.

Ha, silence there! . . .
First words of fear,
Then comfort. All an empty swell!
It seems the lash of trembling Pan
Hath caught you. Speak, if speak ye can.
What tidings? Not a word is clear
Of the whole tale ye tell.

[_The turmoil subsides, the_ LEADER _comes forward_.

LEADER. [_Antistr._

Great beacons in the Argive line
Have burned, my chief, through half the night.

The shipyard timbers seemed to shine.
Then, clear against the light,
Toward Agamemnon's tent the whole
Army in tumult seemed to roll,
As stirred by some strange voice, shoal after shoal.
A night of such discord
Was never seen. And we, in dread
What such things boded, turned and sped
Hither; dost blame us, Lord?

HECTOR (_after a moment of thought_).

No! Welcome, friend, with all thy tale of fear!
It shows they mean to fly: they mean to clear
Decks in the dark and so delude my sight . . . [vv. 55-78]
I like that beacon-burning in the night.
O Zeus above, who checked my conquering way,
Who baulked the hungry lion of his prey
Or ever I could sweep my country clear
Of these despoilers, dost thou hate my spear?
Had but the sun's bright arrows failed me not,
I ne'er had rested till the ships were hot
With fire, and through the tents upon the plain
This bloody hand had passed and passed again!
Myself, I longed to try the battle-cast
By night, and use God's vantage to the last,
But sage and prophet, learned in the way
Of seercraft, bade me wait for dawn of day,
And then--leave no Greek living in the land.
They wait not, they, for what my prophets planned
So sagely. In the dark a runaway
Beats a pursuer.
Through our whole array
Send runners! Bid them shake off sleep and wait
Ready with shield and spear. 'Tis not too late
To catch them as they climb on board, and slash
Their crouching shoulders till the gangways splash
With blood, or teach them, fettered leg and arm,
To dig the stiff clods of some Trojan farm.

LEADER.

My Prince, thy words run fast. Nor thou nor I
Have knowledge yet that the Greeks mean to fly.

HECTOR.

What makes them light their beacons? Tell me, what?

LEADER. [vv. 79-90]

God knows! And, for my part, I like it not.

HECTOR.

What, feared? Thou wouldst be feared of everything!

LEADER.

They never lit such light before, O King.

HECTOR.

They never fled, man, in such wild dismay.

LEADER (_yielding_).

'Twas all thy work.--Judge thou, and we obey.

HECTOR.

My word is simple. Arm and face the foe.

[_A sound of marching without._

LEADER.

Who comes? Aeneas, and in haste, as though
Fraught with some sudden tiding of the night.

Enter AENEAS.

AENEAS.

Hector, what means it? Watchers in affright
Who gather shouting at thy doors, and then
Hold midnight council, shaking all our men?

HECTOR.

To arms, Aeneas! Arm from head to heel!

AENEAS. [vv. 91-109]

What is it? Tidings? Doth the Argive steal
Some march, some ambush in the day's eclipse?

HECTOR.

'Tis flight, man! They are marching to the ships.

AENEAS.

How know'st thou?--Have we proof that it is flight?

HECTOR.

They are burning beacon-fires the livelong night.
They never mean to wait till dawn. Behind
That screen of light they are climbing in the blind
Dark to their ships--unmooring from our coast.

AENEAS (_looking toward the distant fires:
after a pause_).

God guide them!--Why then do you arm the host?

HECTOR.

I mean to lame them in their climbing, I
And my good spear, and break them as they fly.
Black shame it were, and folly worse than shame,
To let these spoilers go the road they came
Unpunished, when God gives them to us here.

AENEAS.

Brother, I would thy wit were like thy spear!
But Nature wills not one man should be wise
In all things; each must seek his separate prize.
And thine is battle pure. There comes this word
Of beacons, on the touch thy soul is stirred: [vv. 110-136]
"They fly! Out horse and chariots!"--Out withal
Past stake and trench, while night hangs like a pall!
Say, when we cross that coiling depth of dyke,
We find the foe not fled, but turned to strike;
One check there, and all hope of good return
Is gone. How can our men, returning, learn
The tricks of the palisade? The chariots how
Keep to the bridges on the trenches' brow,
Save with jammed wheels and broken axles? Aye,
And say thou conquer: other wars yet lie
Before thee. Peleus' son, for all his ire,
Will never let thee touch the ships with fire

Or pounce on his Greek lambs. The man will bide
No wrong and standeth on a tower of pride.
Nay, brother, let the army, head on shield,
Sleep off its long day's labour in the field:
Then, send a spy; find someone who will dare
Creep to yon Argive camp. Then, if 'tis clear
They mean flight, on and smite them as they fly.
Else, if the beacons hide some strategy,
The spy will read it out, and we can call
A council.--Thus speak I, my general.

CHORUS. [_Strophe._

'Tis good! 'Tis wisdom! Prince, give heed
And change the word thy passion gave.
No soldier loveth, in his need,
The glory of a chief too brave.
A spy is best: a spy, to learn
For what strange work those beacons burn
All night beside the guarded wave.

HECTOR. [vv. 137-157]

Ye all so wish it?--Well, ye conquer me.
(_To_ AENEAS) Go thou and calm the allies. There will be
Some stir among them, hearing of these high
And midnight councils.--I will seek the spy
To send to the Greek camp. If there we learn
Of some plot hatching, on the man's return
I straight will call thee and share counsels. So.
But wait attentive. If he says they go
Shipward and plan to escape, one trumpet call
Shall warn thee, and I wait no more, but fall
On camp and hulls, or ever dawn can rise.

AENEAS.

Aye, haste and send him. Now thy plans are wise,
And when need comes I am with thee, sword by sword.
[_Exit_ AENEAS.

HECTOR (_turning to the Guards and other soldiers_).

Ye gathered Trojans, sharers of my word,
Who dares to creep through the Greek lines alone?
Who will so help his fatherland?
Doth none
Offer? Must I do everything, one hand

Alone, to save our allies and our land?

[_A lean dark man pushes forward from the back._

DOLON.

I, Prince!--I offer for our City's sake
To go disguised to the Greek ships, to make
Their counsels mine, and here bring word to thee.
If that be thy full service, I agree.

HECTOR. [vv. 158-171]

Dolon the Wolf! A wise wolf and a true!
Thy father's house was praised when first I knew
Troy: this shall raise it twofold in our eyes.

DOLON.

'Tis wise to do good work, but also wise
To pay the worker. Aye, and fair reward
Makes twofold pleasure, though the work be hard.

HECTOR.

So be it: an honest rule. Do thou lay down
What guerdon likes thee best--short of my crown.

DOLON.

I care not for thy crowned and care-fraught life.

HECTOR.

Wouldst have a daughter of the King to wife?

DOLON.

I seek no mate that might look down on me.

HECTOR.

Good gold is ready, if that tempteth thee.

DOLON.

We live at ease and have no care for gold.

HECTOR.

Well, Troy hath other treasures manifold.

DOLON. [vv. 172-183]

Pay me not now, but when the Greeks are ta'en.

HECTOR.

The Greeks! . . . Choose any save the Atridae twain.

DOLON.

Kill both, an it please thee. I make prayer for none.

HECTOR.

Thou wilt not ask for Ajax, Ileus' son?

DOLON.

A princely hand is skilless at the plough.

HECTOR.

'Tis ransom, then? . . . What prisoner cravest thou?

DOLON.

I said before, of gold we have our fill.

HECTOR.

For spoils and armour . . . thou shalt choose at will.

DOLON.

Nail them for trophies on some temple wall.

HECTOR.

What seeks the man? What prize more rich than all?

DOLON.

Achilles' horses! [_Murmurs of surprise._
Yes, I need a great

Prize. I am dicing for my life with Fate.

HECTOR. [vv. 184-203]

'Fore God, I am thy rival, if thy love
Lies there. Undying was the breed thereof,
And these shall never die, who bear to war
Great Peleus' son, swift gleaming like a star.
Poseidon, rider of the wild sea-drift,
Tamed them, men say, and gave them for his gift
To Peleus.--None the less, since I have stirred
Hopes, I will baulk them not. I pledge my word,
Achilles' steeds, a rare prize, shall be thine.

DOLON.

I thank thee.--'Tis indeed a prize more fine
Than all in Troy.--Grudge me not that; there be
Guerdons abundant for a Prince like thee.
[_Exit_ HECTOR.

CHORUS. [_Antistr._

O peril strange, O fearful prize!
Yet win it and thy life hath wings:
A deed of glory in men's eyes,
And greatness, to be wooed of kings.
If God but hearken to the right,
Thou drinkest to the full this night
The cup of man's imaginings.

DOLON.

[_He stands waiting a moment looking out into the dark._

There lies the way.--But first I must go find
At home some body-shelter to my mind;
Then, forward to the ships of Argolis!

LEADER. [vv. 204-223]

What other raiment wilt thou need than this?

DOLON.

A garb for work, for night; a thieving guise.

LEADER.

'Tis good to learn the wisdoms of the wise.
What will thy wrapping be?

DOLON.

A grey wolf's hide
Shall wrap my body close on either side;
My head shall be the mask of gleaming teeth,
My arms fit in the forepaws, like a sheath,
My thighs in the hinder parts. No Greek shall tell
'Tis not a wolf that walks, half visible,
On four feet by the trenches and around
The ship-screen. When it comes to empty ground
It stands on two.--That is the plan, my friend!

LEADER.

Now Maian Hermes guide thee to thy end
And home safe! Well he loves all counterfeit . . .
Good work is there; may good luck go with it!

DOLON (_to himself gazing out toward the Greek camp_).

There, and then back! . . . And on this belt shall bleed
Odysseus' head--or why not Diomede?--
To prove my truth. Ere dawn can touch the land
I shall be here, and blood upon my hand.
[_Exit_ DOLON.

CHORUS. [vv. 224-255]

Thymbraean, Delian, Birth divine,
That walkest Lycia's inmost shrine,
Come, strong to guard, to guide, to follow,
Come, bow in hand and girt with night,
To help thy Dardans as of old,
When stone by stone thy music rolled--
O conquering Strength, O Sire Apollo!--
Young Ilion into towers of light.

Grant that he reach the shipyard, creep
Keen-eyed through all that host asleep,
Then back to home and hearth, yet living,
Where now his father prays alone:
Yea, grant that, when the Greeks are slain,
Our wolf shall mount with scourge and rein
Those coursers of the sea-god's giving,

Whom Peleus drove in days foregone.

* * * * *

Alone in those Greek ships to stake
His life, for home and country's sake:
'Tis wondrous! Few be hearts so true
When seas across the bulwark break,
And sunlight sickens o'er the crew.
Ah, Phrygia still hath hearts of rock!
The Phrygian spear flies fast and far!
Where shall ye find the fool to mock
Our works in war?

Whom will he stab a-sleeping, whom,
The quick grey wolf, the crawling doom?
Grant that he slay the Spartan! Nay,
Or Agamemnon's head and plume [vv. 256-272]
To Helen bear at dawn of day!
A lightsome dawn to hear her wail
Her brother sworn, her King who came
To Ilion with his thousand sail,
And swords, and flame!

[_As the song ends_ DOLON _reappears, in the disguise of a wolf. The Guards gather round him, bidding him godspeed as he crawls off in the dark towards the Greek camp. Meantime from the direction of Mount Ida has entered a_ SHEPHERD _who goes to_ HECTOR's _door and calls. The Guards seeing him return to their places._

SHEPHERD.

Ho, Master!
[_Enter_ HECTOR _from tent_.
I would it ofttimes were my luck to share
As goodly news with thee as now I bear.

HECTOR.

What dulness hangs about these shepherds! Block,
Com'st thou to us with tidings of thy flock
Here in the field in arms? Who wants thee here?
Thou know'st my house; thou know'st my father's.
There
Tell all about thy lucky lambs.--Now go.

SHEPHERD.

Dull wits, we shepherds! Aye, 'twas alway so.
Yet still, there is some good news to be told.

HECTOR. [vv. 273-288]

A truce there to thy gossip of the fold!
Our dealings are of war, of sword and spear.
[_He turns to go._

SHEPHERD.

Aye; so were mine. That is what brought me here.
[HECTOR's _manner changes_.
A chief comes yonder, leading a great band
Of spears, with help to thee and all the land.

HECTOR.

From whence? How do his name and lineage run?

SHEPHERD.

He comes from Thrace, the River Strymon's son.

HECTOR.

Rhesus! Not Rhesus, here on Trojan soil?

SHEPHERD.

Thou hast guessed. That eases me of half my toil.

HECTOR.

What makes he there towards Ida? All astray
Thus from the plain and the broad waggon-way!

SHEPHERD.

I know not rightly, though one well may guess.
'Tis hard to land at night, with such a press
Of spears, on a strange coast, where rumours tell
Of foes through all the plain-land. We that dwell
On Ida, in the rock, Troy's ancient root
And hearth-stone, were well frighted, through the mute [vv. 289-316]
And wolfish thickets thus to hear him break.
A great and rushing noise those Thracians make,
Marching. We, all astonied, ran to drive

Our sheep to the upmost heights. 'Twas some Argive,
We thought, who came to sweep the mountain clear
And waste thy folds; till suddenly our ear
Caught at their speech, and knew 'twas nothing Greek.
Then all our terror fled. I ran to seek
Some scout or pioneer who led the van
And called in Thracian: "Ho, what child of man
Doth lead you? From what nation do ye bring
This host with aid to Ilion and her king?"
He told me what I sought, and there I stood
Watching; and saw one gleaming like a God,
Tall in the darkness on a Thracian car.
A plate of red gold mated, like a bar,
His coursers' necks, white, white as fallen snow.
A carven targe, with golden shapes aglow,
Hung o'er his back. Before each courser's head
A Gorgon, to the frontlet riveted,
With bells set round--like stories that they tell
Of Pallas' shield--made music terrible.
The numbers of that host no pen could write
Nor reckon; 'tis a multitudinous sight,
Long lines of horsemen, lines of targeteers,
Archers abundant; and behind them veers
A wavering horde, light-armed, in Thracian weed.
A friend is come to Ilion in her need
'Gainst whom no Argive, let him fly or stand,
Shall aught avail nor 'scape his conquering hand.

LEADER. [vv. 317-331]

Lo, when the Gods breathe gently o'er a town,
All runs to good, as water-streams run down.

HECTOR (_bitterly_).

Aye, when my spear hath fortune, when God sends
His favour, I shall find abundant friends.
I need them not; who never came of yore
To help us, when we rolled to death before
The war-swell, and the wind had ripped our sail.
Then Rhesus taught us Trojans what avail
His words are.--He comes early to the feast;
Where was he when the hunters met the beast?
Where, when we sank beneath the Argive spear?

LEADER.

Well may'st thou mock and blame thy friend. Yet here

He comes with help for Troy. Accept him thou.

HECTOR.

We are enough, who have held the wall till now.

LEADER.

Master, dost think already that our foe
Is ta'en?

HECTOR.

I do. To-morrow's light will show.

LEADER. [vv. 332-345]

Have care. Fate often flings a backward cast.

HECTOR.

I hate the help that comes when need is past . . .
Howbeit, once come, I bid him welcome here
As guest--not war-friend; guest to share our cheer.
The thanks are lost, he might have won from us.

LEADER.

My general, to reject an ally thus
Must needs make hatred.

SHEPHERD.

The mere sight of those
I saw would sure cast fear upon our foes.

HECTOR (_yielding reluctantly, with a laugh_).

Ah, well; thy words are prudent; and (_To_ SHEPHERD) thine eyes
See glorious things. With all these panoplies
Of gold that filled our Shepherd's heart with joy,
Bid Rhesus welcome, as war-friend to Troy.

[_Exit_ SHEPHERD; HECTOR _returns to his tent, amid the joy of the soldiers_.

CHORUS.

Now Adrasteia be near and guard
Our lips from sin, lest the end be hard!
But he cometh, he cometh, the Child of the River!
The pride of my heart it shall roll unbarred.

We craved thy coming; yea, need was strong [vv. 346-378]
In the Hall of thy lovers, O child of Song;
Thy mother the Muse and her fair-bridged River
They held thee from us so long, so long!

By Strymon's torrent alone she sang,
And Strymon shivered and coiled and sprang;
And her arms went wide to the wild sweet water,
And the love of the River around her rang.

We hail thee, Fruit of the River's seed,
Young Zeus of the Dawn, on thy starry steed!
O ancient City, O Ida's daughter,
Is God the Deliverer found indeed?

And men shall tell of thee, Ilion mine,
Once more a-harping at day's decline,
'Mid laughing of lovers and lays and dances
And challenge on challenge of circling wine?

When the Greek is smitten that day shall be,
And fled to Argolis over the sea:
O mighty of hand, O leader of lances,
Smite him, and heaven be good to thee!

Thou Rider golden and swift and sheer,
Achilles falters: appear! appear!
The car like flame where the red shield leapeth,
The fell white steeds and the burning spear!

No Greek shall boast he hath seen thy face
And danced again in the dancing place;
And the land shall laugh for the sheaves she reapeth,
Of spoilers dead by a sword from Thrace.

Enter RHESUS _in dazzling white armour, followed by his_ [vv. 379-395]
CHARIOTEER _and Attendants. The_ CHARIOTEER _carries
his golden shield. The_ CHORUS _break into a shout of
"All Hail!"_

LEADER.

All hail, great King! A whelp indeed

Is born in Thracia's lion fold,
Whose leap shall make strong cities bleed.
Behold his body girt with gold,
And hark the pride of bells along
The frontlet of that targe's hold.

CHORUS.

A God, O Troy, a God and more!
'Tis Ares' self, this issue strong
Of Strymon and the Muse of song,
Whose breath is fragrant on thy shore!

Re-enter HECTOR.

RHESUS.

Lord Hector, Prince of Ilion, noble son
Of noble sires, all hail! Long years have run
Since last we greeted, and 'tis joy this day
To see thy fortunes firm and thine array
Camped at the foe's gate. Here am I to tame
That foe for thee, and wrap his ships in flame.

HECTOR.

Thou child of Music and the Thracian flood,
Strymonian Rhesus, truth is alway good
In Hector's eyes. I wear no double heart.
Long, long ago thou shouldst have borne thy part [vv. 396-421]
In Ilion's labours, not have left us here,
For all thy help, to sink beneath the spear.
Why didst thou--not for lack of need made plain!--
Not come, not send, not think of us again?
What grave ambassadors prayed not before
Thy throne, what herald knelt not at thy door?
What pride of gifts did Troy not send to thee?
And thou, a lord of Barbary even as we,
Thou, brother of our blood, like one at sup
Who quaffs his fill and flings away the cup,
Hast flung to the Greeks my city! Yet, long since,
'Twas I that found thee but a little prince
And made thee mighty, I and this right hand;
When round Pangaion and the Paion's land,
Front against front, I burst upon the brood
Of Thrace and broke their targes, and subdued
Their power to thine. The grace whereof, not small,
Thou hast spurned, and when thy kinsmen, drowning, call,

Comest too late. Thou! Others there have been
These long years, not by nature of our kin . . .
Some under yon rough barrows thou canst see
Lie buried; they were true to Troy and me;
And others, yet here in the shielded line
Or mid the chariots, parching in the shine
Of noonday, starving in the winds that bite
Through Ilion's winter, still endure and fight
On at my side. 'Twas not their way, to lie
On a soft couch and, while the cups go by,
Pledge my good health, like thee, in Thracian wine.
I speak as a free man. With thee and thine
Hector is wroth, and tells thee to thy face.

RHESUS. [vv. 422-448]

Thy way is mine, friend. Straight I run my race
In word and deed, and bear no double tongue.
I tell thee, more than thine my heart was wrung,
Yea, angered past all durance, thus to stay
Back from thy battles. 'Twas a folk that lay
Hard on my borders, Scythians of the north;
Just when my host for Troy had started forth,
They fell upon our homes. I had reached the coast
Of the Friendless Sea and purposed to have crossed
My Thracians there. We turned; and all that plain
Is trampled in a mire of Scythian slain
Ploughed by our spears, and blood of Thrace withal
Not stinted. This it was that drowned thy call
For help and held me back from Ilion's need.
I broke their power; the princes of their breed
I took to hostage, made their elders swear
To bring my house due tribute, year by year,
Then, never lagging, crossed the Pontus mouth,
Marched by long stages through Bithynia south
And here am come . . . not drunken with the feast,
As thou wouldst have me be, not lulled to rest
In golden chambers. In this harness hard
I have borne my nights of winter storm that starred
The Euxine into ice and scared the strong
Paionians.
Long I have been, but not too long
To save thee yet. Friend, this is the tenth year
Thou labourest on unceasing, with no clear
Vantage; day creeps by day, and Ares throws
The same red dice for thee and for thy foes.
Now, hear my vow. Before one day's eclipse
I swear to break their wall, to burn their ships

And slay their princes. On the second day [vv. 449-473]
I leave this soil and take my homeward way,
Thy pains relieved. No Trojan of the land
Need move, nor turn the buckler in his hand.
Alone my late-comers will turn the tide
And smite your Greeks, for all their bitter pride.

CHORUS.

[_The Trojan soldiers, who have been listening with delight, here break out in irrepressible applause._

All hail!
Sweet words and faithful heart!
Only may Zeus avert
From those proud lips the Wrath that none may bear!
Never a galleon bore,
Now, nor in days of yore,
Prince like to thee, so valiant and so fair.
How shall Achilles, how
Shall Ajax bear him now,
Or face thy lance? May I but stand that day
Watching to see him reel
Broken beneath thy steel,
And once in blood his many murders pay!

RHESUS.

Yea, more atonement thou shalt take from me
For this slow help.--May Adrasteia see
My heart and pardon!--When we two have set
Troy free from these who compass her with hate,
Soon as the Gods have had their first-fruits, I
With thee will sail--so help me Zeus on high!--
And sack all Hellas with the sword, till these
Doers of deeds shall know what suffering is.

HECTOR. [vv. 474-491]

By heaven, could I once see this peril rolled
Past us, and live in Ilion as of old,
Untrembling, I would thank my gods! To seek
Argos and sack the cities of the Greek--
'Twere not such light work as thou fanciest.

RHESUS.

These Greeks that face thee, are they not their best?

HECTOR.

We seek not better. These do all we need.

RHESUS.

When these are beaten, then, we have done the deed.

HECTOR.

Lose not thy path watching a distant view.

RHESUS.

Thou seem'st content to suffer, not to do?

HECTOR.

I have a kingdom large by mine own right. . . .

What station will best please thee in this fight
To ground the targe and stablish thine array?
Right, left, or midmost in the allies? Say.

RHESUS.

'Twould please me best to fight these Greeks alone.
Yet, if 'twould irk thine honour not to have thrown
One firebrand on the ships with me, why, then
Set us to face Achilles and his men.

HECTOR. [vv. 492-509]

Achilles? Nay, his spear ye cannot meet.

RHESUS.

How so? Fame said he sailed here with the fleet.

HECTOR.

He sailed, and he is here. But some despite
'Gainst the great King now keeps him from the fight.

RHESUS.

Who next to him hath honour in their host?

HECTOR.

Next, to my seeming, Ajax hath the most,
Or Diomede.--But Odysseus is a tough
And subtle fox, and brave; aye, brave enough.
No man of them hath harmed us more than he.
He climbed here to Athena's sanctuary
One night, and stole her image clean away
To the Argive ships. Yes, and another day,
Guised as a wandering priest, in rags, he came
And walked straight through the Gates, made loud acclaim
Of curses on the Greek, spied out alone
All that he sought in Ilion, and was gone--
Gone, and the watch and helpers of the Gate
Dead! And in every ambush they have set
By the old Altar, close to Troy, we know
He sits--a murderous reptile of a foe!

RHESUS. [vv. 510-529]

No brave man seeks so dastardly to harm
His battle-foes; he meets them arm to arm.
This Greek of thine, this sitter like a thief
In ambush, I will make of him my chief
Care. I will take him living, drive a straight
Stake through him, and so star him at the Gate
To feed your wide-winged vultures. 'Tis the death
Most meet for a lewd thief, who pillageth
God's sanctuary, or so we hold in Thrace.

HECTOR (_making no answer_).

Seek first some sleep. There still remains a space
Of darkness.--I will show the spot that best
May suit you, somewhat sundered from the rest.
Should need arise, the password of the night
Is Phoebus: see your Thracians have it right.
[_Turning to the Guards before he goes._
Advance beyond your stations, men, at some
Distance, and stay on watch till Dolon come
With word of the Argives' counsel. If his vow
Prosper, he should be nearing us by now.

[_Exeunt_ HECTOR _and_ RHESUS _and Attendants. The Guards, who
have been below, come forward sleepily from the camp fire,
and sit watching by_ HECTOR's _tent_.

CHORUS.

Say, whose is the watch? Who exchanges
With us? The first planets to rise
Are setting; the Pleiades seven [vv. 530-545]
Move low on the margin of heaven,
And the Eagle is risen and ranges
The mid-vault of the skies.

ANOTHER.

No sleeping yet! Up from your couches
And watch on, the sluggards ye are!
The moon-maiden's lamp is yet burning.

THIRD GUARD.

Oh, the morning is near us, the morning!
Even now his fore-runner approaches,
Yon dim-shining star.

DIVERS GUARDS (_talking_).

Who drew the first night-watch?

ANOTHER.

'Twas one
Koroibos, called the Mygdon's Son.

THE GUARD.

And after?

THE OTHER.

The Mount Taurus men
Had second watch: from them again
The Mysians took it. We came then.

A GUARD.

'Tis surely time. Who will go tell
The fifth watch? 'Tis the Lycians' spell
By now; 'twas thus the portions fell.

ANOTHER. [vv. 546-561]

Nay, hearken! Again she is crying
Where death-laden Simois falls,
Of the face of dead Itys that stunned her,
Of grief grown to music and wonder:
Most changeful and old and undying
The nightingale calls.

ANOTHER.

And on Ida the shepherds are waking
Their flocks for the upland. I hear
The skirl of a pipe very distant.

ANOTHER.

And sleep, it falls slow and insistent.
'Tis perilous sweet when the breaking
Of dawn is so near.

DIVERS GUARDS (_talking_).

Why have we still no word nor sign
Of that scout in the Argive line?

ANOTHER.

I know not; he is long delayed.

ANOTHER.

God send he trip not on the blade
Of some Greek in an ambuscade!

ANOTHER.

It may be. I am half afraid.

LEADER. [vv. 562-572]

Our time is past! Up, men, and tell
The fifth watch. 'Tis the Lycians' spell
Now, as the portions fairly fell.

[_The Guards pass out to waken the Lycians. The stage is empty and dark except for the firelight, when a whisper is heard at the back. Presently enter_ ODYSSEUS _and_ DIOMEDE _in dull leather armour_, DIOMEDE _carrying at his belt_ DOLON's _wolf-skin and mask_.

ODYSSEUS.

Diomede, hist!--A little sound of arms
Clanking. . . or am I full of void alarms?

DIOMEDE.

No. 'Tis some horse tied to the chariot rail
That clanks his chain.--My heart began to fail
A moment, till I heard the horse's champ.

[_They steal on further, keeping in the shadow._

ODYSSEUS.

Mind--in that shade--the watchers of the camp.

DIOMEDE.

I keep in shadow, but I am staring hard.

ODYSSEUS.

Thou know'st the watchword, if we stir some guard?

DIOMEDE. [vv. 573-584]

Phoebus. 'Twas the last sign that Dolon gave.

[_They creep forward in silence to the entrance of_ HECTOR's
tent.

ODYSSEUS.

Now, forward!

[_They dash into the tent, swords drawn; then return._

God! All empty as the grave!

DIOMEDE.

Yet Dolon told us Hector's couch was made
Just here. For none but him I drew this blade.

ODYSSEUS.

What means it? To some ambush is he gone?

DIOMEDE.

Maybe, to work some craft on us at dawn.

ODYSSEUS.

He is hot with courage when he is winning, hot.

DIOMEDE.

What must we do, Odysseus?--He was not
Laid where we thought him, and our hopes are lost.

ODYSSEUS.

Back to our own ship-rampart at all cost!
The God who gave him victory saves him still.
We cannot force Fortune against her will.

DIOMEDE. [vv. 585-598]

Could we not find Aeneas? Or the bed
Of Paris the accurst, and have his head?

ODYSSEUS.

Go by night searching through these lines of men
For chiefs to kill? 'Twere death and death again.

DIOMEDE.

But to go empty back--what shame 'twill be!--
And not one blow struck home at the enemy!

ODYSSEUS.

How not one blow? Did we not baulk and kill
Dolon, their spy, and bear his tokens still?
Dost think the whole camp should be thine to quell?

[DIOMEDE _takes_ DOLON's _wolf-mask off his belt and hangs
it in_ HECTOR's _tent, then turns_.

DIOMEDE.

Good. Now for home! And may the end be well!

[_As they turn there appears at the back a luminous and gigantic shape, the Goddess_ ATHENA.

ATHENA.

What make ye, from these sleepers thus to part
Desponding and with sorrow-wounded heart
If Hector be not granted you to slay
Nor Paris? Little know ye what great stay
Of help is found for Troy. This very night [vv. 599-623]
Rhesus is come; who, if he see the light
Of morning, not Achilles nor the rack
Of Ajax' spear hath power to hold him back,
Ere wall and gate be shattered and inside
Your camp a spear-swept causeway builded wide
To where beached galleys flame above the dead.
Him slay, and all is won. Let Hector's head
Sleep where it lies and draw unvexed breath;
Another's work, not thine, is Hector's death.

ODYSSEUS.

Most high Athena, well I know the sound
Of that immortal voice. 'Tis ever found
My helper in great perils.--Where doth lie
Rhesus, mid all this host of Barbary?

ATHENA.

Full near he lies, not mingled with the host
Of Troy, but here beyond the lines--a post
Of quiet till the dawn, that Hector found.
And near him, by his Thracian chariot bound,
Two snow-white coursers gleam against the wan
Moon, like the white wing of a river swan.
Their master slain, take these to thine own hearth,
A wondrous spoil; there hides not upon earth
A chariot-team of war so swift and fair.

ODYSSEUS.

Say, Diomede, wilt make the men thy share,
Or catch the steeds and leave the fight to me?

DIOMEDE. [vv. 624-638]

I take the killing, thou the stablery:

It needs keen wit and a neat hand. The post
A man should take is where he helpeth most.

ATHENA.

Behold, 'tis Paris, hasting there toward
This tent. Methinks he knoweth from the guard
Some noise of prowling Argives hither blown.

DIOMEDE.

Comes he alone or with his guards?

ATHENA.

Alone;
Toward Hector's quarters, as I deem, he plies
His message. He hath heard some tale of spies.

DIOMEDE.

Then he shall be the first dead Trojan!

ATHENA.

No;
Beyond the ordained end thou canst not go.
Fate hath not willed that Paris by thy deed
Shall die; it is another who must bleed
To-night. Therefore be swift!
[_Exeunt_ ODYSSEUS _and_ DIOMEDE.
For me, my guise
Shall melt and change in Alexander's eyes,
Yea, till he dream 'tis Cypris, his delight
And help in need, that meets him in the night,
And soft shall be my words to him I hate. [vv. 639-658]
So speak I; but on whom my spell is set
He hears not, sees not, though so near I stand.
[_She becomes invisible where she stands._

Enter PARIS.

PARIS.

Ho, Hector! Brother! General of the land!
Sleepest thou still? We need thy waking sight.
Our guards have marked some prowler of the night,
We know not if a mere thief or a spy.

[ATHENA _becomes visible again, but seems changed
and her voice softer_.

ATHENA.

Have comfort thou! Doth not the Cyprian's eye
Mark all thy peril and keep watch above
Thy battles? How shall I forget the love
I owe thee, and thy faithful offices?
To crown this day and all its victories,
Lo, I have guided here to Troy a strong
Helper, the scion of the Muse of song
And Strymon's flood, the crowned stream of Thrace.

PARIS (_standing like one in a dream_).

Indeed thy love is steadfast, and thy grace
Bounteous to Troy and me. Thou art the joy
And jewel of my days, which I to Troy
Have brought, and made thee hers.--O Cyprian,
I heard, not clearly,--'twas some talk that ran
Among the pickets--spies had passed some spot
Close by the camp. The men who saw them not
Talk much, and they who saw, or might have seen, [vv. 659-676]
Can give no sign nor token. It had been
My purpose to find Hector where he lay.

ATHENA.

Fear nothing. All is well in Troy's array.
Hector is gone to help those Thracians sleep.

PARIS.

Thy word doth rule me, Goddess. Yea, so deep
My trust is, that all thought of fear is lost
In comfort, and I turn me to my post.

ATHENA.

Go. And remember that thy fortunes still
Are watched by me, and they who do my will
Prosper in all their ways. Aye, thou shalt prove
Ere long, if I can care for those I love.
[_Exit_ PARIS. _She raises her voice._
Back, back, ye twain! Are ye in love with death?
Laertes' son, thy sword into the sheath!

Our golden Thracian gaspeth in his blood;
The steeds are ours; the foe hath understood
And crowds against you. Haste ye! haste to fly,--
Ere yet the lightning falleth, and ye die!

[ATHENA _vanishes; a noise of tumult is heard_.

_Enter a crowd of Thracians running in confusion, in the midst
of them_ ODYSSEUS _and_ DIOMEDE.

VOICES (_amid the tumult_).

Ha! Ha!--At them! At them! After them! Down with them!--Where are they?

CAPTAIN. [vv. 677-685]

Who is that fellow? Look! That yonder!

A MAN.

Rascal thieves, the sort that crawl
And vex an army in the dark!

CAPTAIN.

Ho, this way! Follow! This way all!

[_They pursue_ ODYSSEUS _and_ DIOMEDE; _catch
them and bring them back_.

A MAN.

I have them! I have caught them!

CAPTAIN (_to_ ODYSSEUS).

Whence comest thou? What art thou? Say; what captain and what company?

ODYSSEUS (_indignantly_).

'Tis not for thee to know. This day thou diest for thy knavery!

CAPTAIN.

Stop! Give the watchword quick, before I have thy body on my pike.

ODYSSEUS (_in a tone of authority_).

Halt every man and have no fear!

CAPTAIN.

Come, gather round. Be quick to strike.

ODYSSEUS (_to_ CAPTAIN). [vv. 686-689]

'Twas thou that killed King Rhesus!

CAPTAIN.

No: 'tis I that kill the man that killed . . .

[_Flies at_ ODYSSEUS, _but other men hold him back_.

ODYSSEUS.

Hold back all!

VOICES.

No more holding back!

ODYSSEUS (_as they attack him_).

What, strike an ally in the field?

CAPTAIN.

Then give the watchword!

ODYSSEUS.

Phoebus.

CAPTAIN.

Right. Ho, every man hold back his spear!--
Then know'st thou where the men are gone?

ODYSSEUS.

We saw them running, somewhere here.

[_He makes off into the darkness._ DIOMEDE _follows, and some Thracians_.

CAPTAIN. [vv. 690-703]

Off every one upon their track!

A MAN.

Or should we rouse the army?

CAPTAIN.

No;
To stir the allies in the night and make more panic!
Let us go.

[_The Thracians go off in pursuit. Meantime the original Guards who form the Chorus have hastened back. The two Greeks are presently seen crossing at the back in a different direction._

CHORUS.

Who was the man that passed?
Who, that, so madly bold.
Even as I held him fast,
Laughed, and I loosed my hold?
Where shall I find him now?
What shall I deem of him,
To steal thro' the guards a-row,
Quaking not, eye nor limb,
On thro' the starlight dim?
Is he of Thessaly,
Born by the Locrian sea,
Or harvester of some starved island's corn?
What man hath seen his face?
What was his name or race,
What the high God by whom his sires have sworn?

DIVERS GUARDS (_talking_). [vv. 704-724]

This night must be Odysseus' work, or whose?--
Odysseus? Aye, to judge by ancient use.--
Odysseus surely!--That is thy belief?--
What else? It seems he hath no fear
Of such as we!--Whom praise ye there?
Whose prowess? Say!--Odysseus.--Nay,
Praise not the secret stabbing of a thief!

CHORUS.

He came once, of old,
Up thro' the city throng,
Foam on his lips, a-cold,
Huddled in rags that hung
Covering just the sword
Hid in his mantle's pleat;
His face grimed and scored,
A priest of wandering feet,
Who begged his bread in the street.
Many and evil things
He cast on the brother kings
Like one long hurt, who nurseth anger sore;
Would that a curse, yea, would
The uttermost wrath of God
Had held those feet from walking Ilion's shore!

DIVERS GUARDS (_talking_).

Odysseus or another, 'tis the guard
Will weep for this. Aye, Hector will be hard.--
What will he say?--He will suspect.--Suspect?
What evil? What should make you fear?-- [vv. 725-737]
'Twas we that left a passage clear.--
A passage?--Yea, for these men's way,
Who came by night into the lines unchecked.

[_A sound of moaning outside in the darkness, which has been heard during the last few lines, now grows into articulate words._

VOICE.

Woe, woe!
The burden of the wrath of fate!

GUARDS.

Ha, listen! Wait.
Crouch on the ground; it may be yet
Our man is drawing to the net.

VOICE.

Woe, woe!
The burden of the hills of Thrace!

LEADER.

An ally? None of Hellene race.

VOICE.

Woe, woe!
Yea, woe to me and woe to thee,
My master! Once to set thine eye
On Ilion the accurst, and die!

LEADER (_calling aloud_).

Ho there! What ally passes? The dim night
Blurreth mine eyes; I cannot see thee right.

VOICE. [vv. 738-756]

Ho, some one of the Trojan name!
Where sleeps your king beneath his shield,
Hector? What marshal of the field
Will hear our tale . . . the men who came
And struck us and were gone; and we,
We woke and there was nought to see,
But our own misery.

LEADER.

I cannot hear him right; it sounds as if
The Thracians were surprised or in some grief.

[_There enters a wounded man, walking with difficulty; he is the
Thracian Charioteer who came with_ RHESUS.

THRACIAN.

The army lost and the king slain,
Stabbed in the dark! Ah, pain! pain!
This deep raw wound . . . Oh, let me die
By thy side, Master, by thy side!
In shame together let us lie
Who came to save, and failed and died.

LEADER.

This needs no surmise: 'tis disaster plain
That comes. He speaketh of some ally slain.

THRACIAN.

Disaster, yea: and with disaster shame,
Which lights Disaster to a twofold flame
Of evil. For to die in soldier's wise, [vv. 757-787]
Since die we needs must . . . though the man who dies
Hath pain . . . to all his house 'tis praise and pride;
But we, like laggards and like fools we died!
When Hector's hand had showed us where to rest
And told the watchword, down we lay, oppressed
With weariness of that long march, and slept
Just as we fell. No further watch was kept,
Our arms not laid beside us; by the horse
No yoke nor harness ordered. Hector's force
Had victory, so my master heard, and lay
Secure, just waiting for the dawn of day
To attack. So thought we all, and our lines broke
And slept. After a little time I woke,
Thinking about my horses, that the morn
Must see them yoked for war. I found the corn
And gave them plenteously. Then in the deep
Shadow I saw two men who seemed to creep
Close by our line, but swiftly, as I stirred,
Crouched and were seeking to make off unheard.
I shouted then, and bade them keep away:
Two thieves, I thought, from the great host that lay
Round us. They never answered, and, for me,
I said no more but turned and presently
Was sleeping. In my sleep there came a dream.
I seemed to see the horses--mine own team
I had trained long since and drove at Rhesus' side--
But wolves were on their backs, wolves, couched astride,
Who drove and scourged; I saw the horses rear
And stagger with wide nostrils, stiff with fear,
And, starting up to drive the beasts away,
I woke.--A terror of great darkness lay [vv. 788-809]
About me, but I lifted up my head
And listened. There was moaning, like the dead
That moan at night, and over me there flowed,
So soft, so warm--it was my master's blood,
Who writhed beside me, dying! With a bound
I sprang up, empty-handed, groping round
For spear or sword, when, lo, a young strong man
Was close to me and slashed, and the sword ran
Deep through my flank. I felt its passage well,
So deep, so wide, so spreading . . . then I fell.
And they, they got the bridles in their hand
And fled. . . . Ah! Ah! This pain. I cannot stand.
[_The Guards catch him as he reels, and lay him on
the ground._

I know, I saw, thus much. But why or how
Those dead men went to death I cannot know,
Nor by whose work. But this I say; God send
'Tis not foul wrong wrought on us by a friend.

LEADER.

Good charioteer of that ill-fortuned king,
Suspect us not. 'Tis Greeks have done this thing.
But yonder Hector comes. He hath been shown
The foul deed, and thy sorrows are his own.

Enter HECTOR _in wrath, with a band of Guards_.

HECTOR.

Ye workers of amazement! Have your eyes
No sight? Ye watch and let these Argive spies
Pass--and our friends are butchered in their sleep-- [vv. 810-834]
And then pass back unwounded, laughing deep
Amid the galleys at the news they bring
Of Trojan sluggards and the fool their king?
Great God, ye never baulked them as they came,
Nor smote them as they went!
[_His eye falls on the_ CAPTAIN.
Who bears the blame
Of this but thou? Thou wast the watcher set
To guard this host till morn. I tell thee yet
For this deed--I have sworn by Zeus our Lord!--
The scourge of torment or the headsman's sword
Awaits thee. Else, be Hector in your thought
Writ down a babbler and a man of nought.

LEADER (_grovelling before_ HECTOR).

Woe, woe! It was for thee, only for thee,
I must have gone, O Help and Majesty,
That time with message that the fires were burning.
Mine eye was keen; I swear by Simois river,
It never drooped nor slumbered, never, never,
From eve till morning!
My master, verily, I am innocent utterly,
Build not such wrath against me, Lord, nor harden
Thy heart; let Time be judge; and if in deed
Or word I have offended, let me bleed!
Bury me here alive! I ask no pardon.

[HECTOR _is standing over him ready to strike when the_

CHARIOTEER _speaks_.

THRACIAN.

Why threaten them? Art thou a Greek to blind
My barbarous wit so nimbly, in a wind
Of words? This work was thine. And no man's head [vv. 835-861]
Is asked by us, the wounded and the dead,
Save thine. It needs more play, and better feigned,
To hide from me that thou hast slain thy friend
By craft, to steal his horses.--That is why
He stabs his friends. He prays them earnestly,
Prays them to come; they came and they are dead.
A cleaner man was Paris, when he fled
With his host's wife. He was no murderer.
Profess not thou that any Greek was there
To fall on us. What Greek could pass the screen
Of Trojan posts in front of us, unseen?
Thyself was stationed there, and all thy men.
What man of yours was slain or wounded when
Your Greek spies came? Not one; 'tis we, behind,
Are wounded, and some worse than wounded, blind
Forever to the sunlight. When we seek
Our vengeance, we shall go not to the Greek.
What stranger in that darkness could have trod
Straight to where Rhesus lay--unless some God
Pointed his path? They knew not, whispered not,
Rhesus had ever come. . . . 'Tis all a plot.

HECTOR (_steadied and courteous again_).

Good allies I have had since first the Greek
Set foot in Troy, and never heard them speak
Complaint of Hector. Thou wilt be the first.
I have not, by God's mercy, such a thirst
For horses as to murder for their sake.
[_He turns to his own men._
Odysseus! Yet again Odysseus! Take
All the Greek armies, is there one but he
Could have devised, or dared, this devilry? [vv. 862-876]
I fear him; yea, fear in mine own despite,
Lest Dolon may have crossed him in the night
And perished; 'tis so long he cometh not.

THRACIAN.

I know not who Odysseus is, nor what.
I know it was no Greek that wounded us.

HECTOR.

To think thus pleasures thee? Well, have it thus.

THRACIAN.

Home, home! To die at home and rest my head!

HECTOR.

Nay, die not, friend. We have enough of dead.

THRACIAN.

How can I live? Lost, and my master slain.

HECTOR.

My house will shelter thee and heal thy pain.

THRACIAN.

Thy house? Will murderers' nursing give me peace?

HECTOR.

Still the same tale! This man will never cease.

THRACIAN.

My curse rest--not on Hector, but on those
Who stabbed us, as thou say'st.--Ah, Justice knows!

HECTOR. [vv. 877-891]

There, lift him.--Bear him to my house. Take pains,
If care can do it, that the man complains
No more of Troy.--Ye others, bear withal
To Priam and the Elders of the Wall
My charge, that, where the cart-road from the plain
Branches, they make due burial for our slain.

[_One party of Guards lifts carefully the wounded_ THRACIAN
_and goes off bearing him: another departs with the message
to Troy_.

CHORUS.

Back from the heights of happiness,
Back, back, to labour and distress
Some god that is not ours doth lead
Troy and her sons; He sows the seed,
Who knows the reaping?

[_In the air at the back there appears a Vision of the_ MUSE
holding the body of her dead son RHESUS.

Ah! Ah!
My king, what cometh? There appears
Some Spirit, like a mist of tears;
And in her arms a man lieth,
So young, so wearied unto death;
To see such vision presageth
Wrath and great weeping.

[_The Guards hide their heads in their mantles._

MUSE.

Nay, look your fill, ye Trojans. It is I,
The many-sistered Muse, of worship high
In wise men's hearts, who come to mourn mine own [vv. 892-914]
Most pitifully loved, most injured, son,
For whose shed blood Odysseus yet shall pay
Vengeance, who crawled and stabbed him where he lay.

With a dirge of the Thracian mountains,
I mourn for thee, O my son.
For a mother's weeping, for a galley's launching, for
the way to Troy;
A sad going, and watched by spirits of evil.
His mother chid him to stay, but he rose and went.
His father besought him to stay, but he went in
anger.
Ah, woe is me for thee, thou dear face,
My beloved and my son!

LEADER.

Goddess, if tears for such as thee may run
In our low eyes, I weep for thy dead son.

MUSE.

I say to thee: Curse Odysseus,

And cursed be Diomede!
For they made me childless, and forlorn for ever, of
the flower of sons.
Yea, curse Helen, who left the houses of Hellas.
She knew her lover, she feared not the ships and sea.
She called thee, called thee, to die for the sake of Paris,
Beloved, and a thousand cities
She made empty of good men.
O conquered Thamyris, is this thy bane [vv. 915-941]
Returned from death to pierce my heart again?
Thy pride it was, and bitter challenge cast
'Gainst all the Muses, did my flesh abase
To bearing of this Child, what time I passed
Through the deep stream and looked on Strymon's face,
And felt his great arms clasp me, when to old
Pangaion and the earth of hoarded gold
We Sisters came with lutes and psalteries,
Provoked to meet in bitter strife of song
That mountain wizard, and made dark the eyes
Of Thamyris, who wrought sweet music wrong.
I bore thee, Child; and then, in shame before
My sisterhood, my dear virginity,
I stood again upon thy Father's shore
And cast thee to the deeps of him; and he
Received and to no mortal nursing gave
His child, but to the Maidens of the Wave.
And well they nursed thee, and a king thou wast
And first of Thrace in war; yea, far and near
Through thine own hills thy bloody chariot passed,
Thy battered helm flashed, and I had no fear;
Only to Troy I charged thee not to go:
I knew the fated end: but Hector's cry,
Borne overseas by embassies of woe,
Called thee to battle for thy friends and die.

And thou, Athena--nothing was the deed
Odysseus wrought this night nor Diomede--
'Tis thine, all thine; dream not thy cruel hand
Is hid from me! Yet ever on thy land
The Muse hath smiled; we gave it praise above
All cities, yea, fulfilled it with our love. [vv. 942-963]
The light of thy great Mysteries was shed
By Orpheus, very cousin of this dead
Whom thou hast slain; and thine high citizen
Musaeus, wisest of the tribes of men,
We and Apollo guided all his way:
For which long love behold the gift ye pay!
I wreathe him in my arms; I wail his wrong

Alone, and ask no other mourner's song.
[_She weeps over_ RHESUS.

LEADER.

Hector, thou hearest. We were guiltless here,
And falsely spake that Thracian charioteer.

HECTOR.

Always I knew it. Had we any need
Of seers to tell this was Odysseus' deed?
For me, what could I else, when I beheld
The hosts of Argos camped upon this field,
What but with prayers and heralds bid my friend
Come forth and fight for Ilion ere the end?
He owed me that.--Yet, now my friend is slain,
His sorrow is my sorrow. On this plain
I will uplift a wondrous sepulchre,
And burn about it gifts beyond compare
Of robes and frankincense. To Troy's relief
He came in love and parteth in great grief.

MUSE.

My son shall not be laid in any grave
Of darkness; thus much guerdon will I crave
Of Death's eternal bride, the heavenly-born [vv. 964-985]
Maid of Demeter, Life of fruits and corn,
To set this one soul free. She owes me yet,
For Orpheus widowed, an abiding debt.
To me he still must be--that know I well--
As one in death, who sees not. Where I dwell
He must not come, nor see his mother's face.
Alone for ever, in a caverned place
Of silver-veined earth, hid from men's sight,
A Man yet Spirit, he shall live in light:
As under far Pangaion Orpheus lies,
Priest of great light and worshipped of the wise.
Howbeit an easier anguish even to me
Falls than to Thetis in her azure sea;
For her son too shall die; and sorrowing,
First on the hills our band for thee shall sing,
Then for Achilles by the weeping wave.
Pallas could murder thee, but shall not save
Thy foe; too swift Apollo's bolt shall fly.
O fleshly loves of sad mortality,
O bitter motherhood of these that die,

She that hath wisdom will endure her doom,
The days of emptiness, the fruitless womb;
Not love, not bear love's children to the tomb.

[_The_ VISION _rises through the air and vanishes_.

LEADER.

The dead man sleepeth in his mother's care;
But we who battle still--behold, the glare
Of dawn that rises. Doth thy purpose hold,
Hector, our arms are ready as of old.

HECTOR. [vv. 986-996]

March on; and bid the allies with all speed
Be armed, bind fast the yoke upon the steed,
Then wait with torches burning, till we sound
The Tuscan trump.--This day we shall confound,
God tells me, their Greek phalanx, break their high
Rampart and fire the galleys where they lie.
[_Pointing to the dawn._
Yon first red arrow of the Sun, that brings
The dawn to Troy, hath freedom on his wings.

During the following lines HECTOR _goes to his tent to get his shield, and as he enters sees_ DOLON's _bloody wolf-skin hanging. He takes it, looks at it, and throws it down without a word. Then he puts on his helmet, takes his shield and spear, and follows the Guards as they march off._

CHORUS.

The Chief hath spoken: let his will
Be law, ye Trojans.--Raise the cry
To Arms! To Arms! and down the line
Of allies pass the battle-sign.
The God of Ilion liveth still;
And men may conquer ere they die.
[_Exeunt._

*** END OF THE PROJECT GUTENBERG EBOOK THE RHESUS OF EURIPIDES ***

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